Winter Storm Checklist

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/how-to-prepare-for-a-winter-storm/, which lists its sources (Ready.gov, CDC, NHTSA, National Fire Protection Association and American Red Cross guidance). Updated November 5, 2026.

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

Before the storm: your home checklist

Plan to be on your own for several days. A winter storm can cut off heat, power and phone service, and older adults, children, people who are sick and pets are at greater risk.

- [ ] Water: 1 gallon per person per day for at least 3 days
  The CDC's minimum, for drinking, cooking and brushing teeth. Our water calculator works out your total.
- [ ] Food that needs no cooking or refrigeration, and a manual can opener
- [ ] Flashlights or headlamps and extra batteries
  Use flashlights, not candles, in the dark.
- [ ] A battery-powered or hand-crank radio, and a NOAA Weather Radio with tone alert
- [ ] Charged power banks and a car phone charger
- [ ] Enough prescription medicine to last if you can't get out, plus a first-aid kit
- [ ] A warm blanket or sleeping bag for each person, plus hats, gloves and warm layers
- [ ] Food and extra water for pets
- [ ] Smoke alarms and carbon monoxide alarms with battery backup, tested
  Ready.gov lists carbon monoxide poisoning among the main dangers of winter storms.
- [ ] Insulation, caulking and weather stripping to keep the cold out
- [ ] Know where your main water shut-off valve is
  If a pipe bursts, turning off the water fast limits the damage.

Can't afford heating bills or repairs to keep the cold out? The Low Income Home Energy Assistance Program (LIHEAP) can help with heating costs and weatherization.

How to keep pipes from freezing

Water expands as it freezes, and the pressure can split metal or plastic pipes. Pipes freeze most often where they're exposed to cold: outdoor hose bibs, pool and sprinkler lines, pipes in unheated basements, crawl spaces, attics, garages and kitchen cabinets, and pipes along outside walls with little insulation.

BEFORE COLD WEATHER

- [ ] Disconnect, drain and store garden hoses
- [ ] Close the inside valves that feed outdoor faucets, then open the outdoor faucets so they can drain
  Leave them open, so any water left in the pipe can expand without breaking it.
- [ ] Drain pool and sprinkler supply lines the way the manufacturer or installer says, without adding antifreeze unless they tell you to
  Antifreeze is dangerous to people, pets and wildlife.
- [ ] Insulate attics, basements and crawl spaces
- [ ] Wrap exposed pipes with pipe sleeves or UL-listed heat tape or heat cable
  Even ¼ inch of newspaper gives some protection where freezes are rare and short.

ON VERY COLD NIGHTS

- [ ] Let cold water drip from faucets served by exposed pipes
  Even a trickle of moving water helps stop a pipe freezing.
- [ ] Open the cabinet doors under kitchen and bathroom sinks, after moving cleaners and chemicals out of children's reach
  Warm air reaches the pipes.
- [ ] Keep the garage door closed if water lines run through the garage
- [ ] Keep the thermostat at the same temperature day and night
- [ ] Going away? Leave the heat on, set no lower than 55°F

IF A PIPE FREEZES

Only a trickle from the faucet usually means a frozen pipe, often along an outside wall or where the water line comes in through the foundation.

1. Keep the faucet open. Running water helps melt the ice as it thaws.
2. Warm that section of pipe with an electric heating pad wrapped around it, a hair dryer, a space heater kept away from anything that can burn, or towels soaked in hot water.
3. Keep warming it until full water pressure comes back, then check your other faucets: if one pipe froze, others may have too.
4. Call a licensed plumber if you can't find or reach the frozen section, or can't thaw it.

Never thaw a pipe with an open flame. Don't use a blowtorch, a kerosene or propane heater, a charcoal stove or any other open-flame device.

If the power goes out in the cold

Carbon monoxide is one of a winter storm's biggest dangers. Use generators and grills only outdoors, and never heat your home with a gas stovetop or oven. If the carbon monoxide alarm sounds, or anyone has a headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea or confusion, get everyone into fresh air right away, then call 911. People who are asleep can die before they notice anything.

- Run a generator outdoors only, at least 20 feet from windows, doors and attached garages, and let it cool before refueling.
- Keep space heaters at least 3 feet from anything that can burn, and turn them off when you leave the room or go to bed.
- Use the blankets or sleeping bags from your kit, and dress in warm layers.
- If you can't keep warm at home, go somewhere with heat, such as a warming center.

Our power outage checklist covers the rest, including how to keep one room warm and how long food in the fridge and freezer stays safe.

Frostbite and hypothermia: the signs

Limit time outside, and wear layers when you go out. Watch everyone for these signs, especially older adults and children.

Condition	Signs	What to do
Hypothermia	Shivering, exhaustion, confusion, fumbling hands, memory loss, slurred speech or drowsiness. A body temperature below 95°F is an emergency: call 911.	Get to a warm room. Warm the center of the body first: chest, neck, head and groin. Keep the person dry and wrapped in warm blankets, including the head and neck.
Frostbite	Numbness, and white or grayish-yellow skin that feels firm or waxy, usually on the face, fingers or toes.	Get to a warm room. Soak the area in warm water, or warm it with body heat. Don't massage it or use a heating pad.

Shoveling snow is hard work, and overexertion raises the risk of a heart attack. Take it slowly and rest often.

Driving and your car

- **Stay off the roads** if you can. Check the forecast and road conditions before any trip.
- **Keep the gas tank full,** or an electric car charged. A full tank also keeps the fuel line from freezing.
- **Pack a winter car kit:** a shovel, ice scraper, sand or kitty litter, jumper cables, a flashlight, blankets and warm clothes, water, snacks and a phone charger. Our car emergency kit list has the full checklist.
- **If you're stranded, stay with the car.** Tie something bright to the antenna or a window, and keep the dome light on. Clear snow from the exhaust pipe, and run the engine only now and then, just long enough to stay warm. Don't run it for long with the windows up or in an enclosed space.